

Parts of Speech

Introduction

- **Every word is a part of speech.** The term “part of speech” refers to the role a word plays in a sentence. And like any workplace or any TV show with an ensemble cast, these roles were designed **to work together, and not in isolation.**
- Read on to learn about the different parts of speech that the words we use every day fall into, and how we use them together to communicate ideas clearly.

- Traditional grammar classifies words based on eight **parts of speech**: the verb, the noun, the pronoun, the adjective, the adverb, the preposition, the conjunction, and the interjection.
- Each **part of speech** explains not what the word *is*, but how the word *is used*. In fact, the same word can be a noun in one sentence and a verb or adjective in the next.

Noun

- A **noun** is a word used to name a person, animal, place, thing, and abstract idea. The **highlighted** words in the following sentences are all nouns:
- Late last **year** our **neighbours** bought a **goat**.
- **Portia White** was an **opera singer**.
- The **bus inspector** looked at all the **passengers' passes**.
- According to **Plutarch**, the **library** at **Alexandria** was destroyed in 48 B.C.
- **Philosophy** is of little **comfort** to the **starving**.

Proper nouns vs. common nouns

- One important distinction to be made is whether a noun is a proper noun or a common noun. A proper noun is a specific name of a person, place, or thing, and is always capitalized.

Example:

- Does Tina have much homework to do this evening?
- Tina is the name of a specific person.

- A common noun is the generic name of an item in a class or group and is not capitalized unless appearing at the beginning of a sentence or in a title.
- **The girl crossed the river.**

Girl is a common noun; we do not learn the identity of the girl by reading this sentence, though we know the action she takes. River is also a common noun in this sentence.

Common or generic nouns can be broken down into three subtypes: **concrete nouns, abstract nouns, and collective nouns**. A concrete noun is something that is perceived by the senses; something that is physical or real.

A noun can function in a sentence as a subject, a direct object, an indirect object, a subject complement, an object complement, an adjective or an adverb.

Noun Gender

- Many common nouns, like "engineer" or "teacher," can refer to men or women. Once, many English nouns would change form depending on their gender -- for example, a man was called an "author" while a woman was called an "authoress" -- but this use of **gender-specific nouns** is very rare today. Those that are still used occasionally tend to refer to occupational categories, as in the following:
- David Garrick was a very prominent eighteenth-century actor.
- Sarah Siddons was at the height of her career as an actress in the 1780s.
- The manager was trying to write a want ad, but he couldn't decide whether he was advertising for a "waiter" or a "waitress".

Possessive Nouns

- In the possessive case, a noun or pronoun changes its form to show that it owns or is closely related to something else. Usually, nouns become possessive by adding a combination of an apostrophe and the letter "s."
- You can form the possessive case of a singular noun that does not end in "s" by adding an apostrophe and "s," as in the following sentences:
- The red suitcase is **Cassandra's**.
- The only luggage that was lost was the **prime minister's**.
- The exhausted recruits were woken before dawn by the **drill sergeant's** screams.

Countable Nouns

- A **countable noun** (or **count noun**) is a noun with both a singular and a plural form, and it names anything (or anyone) that you can *count*. You can make a countable noun plural and attach it to a plural verb in a sentence. Countable nouns are the opposite of non-countable nouns and collective nouns.
- In each of the following sentences, the **highlighted** words are countable nouns:
- We painted the **table** red and the **chairs** blue.
- Since he inherited his **aunt's library**, Ali spends every **weekend** indexing his **books**.
- Sarah found six silver **dollars** in the **toe** of a **sock**.
- The oak **tree** lost three **branches** in the **hurricane**.

Collective Nouns

- A **collective noun** is a noun naming a group of things, animals, or persons. You could count the individual members of the group, but you usually think of the group as a whole is generally as one unit. You need to be able to recognise collective nouns in order to maintain **subject-verb agreement**. A collective noun is similar to a non-countable noun, and is roughly the opposite of a countable noun.

Examples

- In each of the following sentences, the **highlighted** word is a collective noun:
- The **flock** of geese spends most of its time in the pasture.
The collective noun "flock" takes the singular verb "spends."
- The **jury** is dining on take-out chicken tonight.
In this example the collective noun "jury" is the subject of the singular compound verb "is dining."
- The steering **committee** meets every Wednesday afternoon.
Here the collective noun "committee" takes a singular verb, "meets."
- The **class** was startled by the bursting light bulb.
In this sentence the word "class" is a collective noun and takes the singular compound verb "was startled."

Verb

- The verb is perhaps the most important part of the sentence. A **verb** or compound verb asserts something about the subject of the sentence and express actions, events, or states of being. The verb or compound verb is the critical element of the predicate of a sentence.
- In each of the following sentences, the verb or compound verb is **highlighted**:
- In early October, Tom **will plant** twenty tulip bulbs.
- Karl Creelman bicycled around the world in 1899, but his diaries and his bicycle **were destroyed**.

Pronoun

- A **pronoun** can replace a noun or another pronoun. You use pronouns like "he," "which," "none," and "you" to make your sentences less cumbersome and less repetitive.
- Grammarians classify pronouns into several types, including the personal pronoun, the demonstrative pronoun, the interrogative pronoun, the indefinite pronoun, the relative pronoun, the reflexive pronoun, and the.
- Personal Pronouns A **personal pronoun** refers to a specific person or thing and changes its form to indicate person, number, gender, and case.

- A **subjective personal pronoun** indicates that the pronoun is acting as the subject of the sentence. The subjective personal pronouns are "I," "you," "she," "he," "it," "we," "you," "they."
- In the following sentences, each of the **highlighted** words is a subjective personal pronoun and acts as the subject of the sentence:
- **I** was glad to find the bus pass in the bottom of the green knapsack.
- **You** are surely the strangest child **I** have ever met.
- After many years, **they** returned to their homeland.

- An **objective personal pronoun** indicates that the pronoun is acting as an object of a verb, compound verb, preposition, or infinitive phrase. The objective personal pronouns are: "me," "you," "her," "him," "it," "us," "you," and "them."
- Seamus stole the selkie's skin and forced **her** to live with **him**.

- A **possessive pronoun** indicates that the pronoun is acting as a marker of possession and defines who owns a particular object or person. The **possessive personal pronouns** are "mine," "yours," "hers," "his," "its," "ours," and "theirs." Note that possessive personal pronouns are very similar to possessive adjectives like "my," "her," and "their."
- The smallest gift is **mine**.
- This is yours.
- Theirs will be delivered tomorrow.

- An **interrogative pronoun** is used to ask questions. The interrogative pronouns are "who," "whom," "which," "what" and the compounds formed with the suffix "ever" ("whoever," "whomever," "whichever," and "whatever"). Note that either "which" or "what" can also be used as an interrogative adjective, and that "who," "whom," or "which" can also be used as a relative pronoun.
- You will find "who," "whom," and occasionally "which" used to refer to people, and "which" and "what" used to refer to things and to animals.
- "Who" acts as the subject of a verb, while "whom" acts as the object of a verb, preposition, or a verbal.

- The **highlighted** word in each of the following sentences is an interrogative pronoun:
- **Which** wants to see the dentist first?“
- Which" is the subject of the sentence.
- **Who** wrote the novel Rockbound?
- Similarly "who" is the subject of the sentence.
- **Whom** do you think we should invite?
- In this sentence, "whom" is the object of the verb "invite."
- To **whom** do you wish to speak?

